the event of a close fight, victory in each seat will be critical, something the big names can ensure. "The party wants to project to the workers and the voters at large that all these leaders are in the fray for the top job, that Chouhan is not the only option," says a party functionary in Bhopal.

WHY YOU CAN'T IGNORE CHOUHAN

However, even as the BJP is trying to eclipse Chouhan, it cannot relegate the chief minister completely to the background. For one, if the BJP had any clear leadership options, it would have changed the CM, as it has done in multiple states ahead of the polls there. If it has not done so thus far, it's because the party realises Chouhan is still their tallest leader in the state. Moreover, with the Bihar caste survey pushing OBC (Other Backward Class) politics centre stage, Chouhan being from the Kirar OBC community, denying him due importance can backfire.

And if Nari Shakti be the flavour of the season, Chouhan has a head start there too. The Ladli Behna Scheme, which he announced earlier this year, will be a key poll plank in MP. The government claims that 13 million women are getting Rs 1,250 per month as part of the scheme. Chouhan has promised to raise this sum to Rs 3,000 in days to come. The CM has also added a number of other benefits to the scheme's beneficiaries, among them gas cylinders for Rs 450 per month.

Others dismiss talk of anti-incumbency altogether. If indeed it was a factor, why would the party give tickets to 24 of the 33 ministers in Chouhan's cabinet, they ask. Political analyst Girija Shankar echoes the thought. "How do you detect anti-incumbency? The party has accepted all of Chouhan's programmes and is seeking votes on that basis. Anti-incumbency may be a factor in Bhopal where the CM is seen regularly, but not in rural MP where his visits are less frequent," he says.

THE CONGRESS COUNTER

The Grand Old Party is planning to fulfil the unfinished business of the last time before Scindia pulled the rug from under the Kamal Nath government's feet. The rural sector and farmers will continue to be its focus, with the party promising to waive farm loans pending since the time the Congress regime collapsed in 2020, besides free power to those holding 5-HP agricultural connections. The Congress has also promised a return to the Old Pension Scheme. And if the BJP is giving women Rs 1,250 under Ladli Behna, the Congress is promising Rs 1,500. Likewise, it is offering gas cylinders for Rs 500.

In addition, the party is also planning to play the caste census card in MP. It was the Kamal Nath-led government that had raised the OBC quota from 14 per cent to 27 per cent in 2020. The party feels the move will still hold it in good stead. Besides, it is hoping to raise the issues of atrocities on SCs and STs, where MP does not have a good record, and corruption. The Karnataka-style percentage-based allegations, though, are not sticking to the Chouhan government.

The party has also yet to announce candidates. "We'll commence ticket distribution after the shraadh period ends," Nath told the media. Given his previous experience, the PCC president will certainly take no chances. ■



FUELLING PUBLIC IRE Former Congress CM Kamal Nath at the Jan Akrosh Yatra

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